



Darfur Protection of Civilians Advocacy Note

SAF/RSF conflict in Darfur

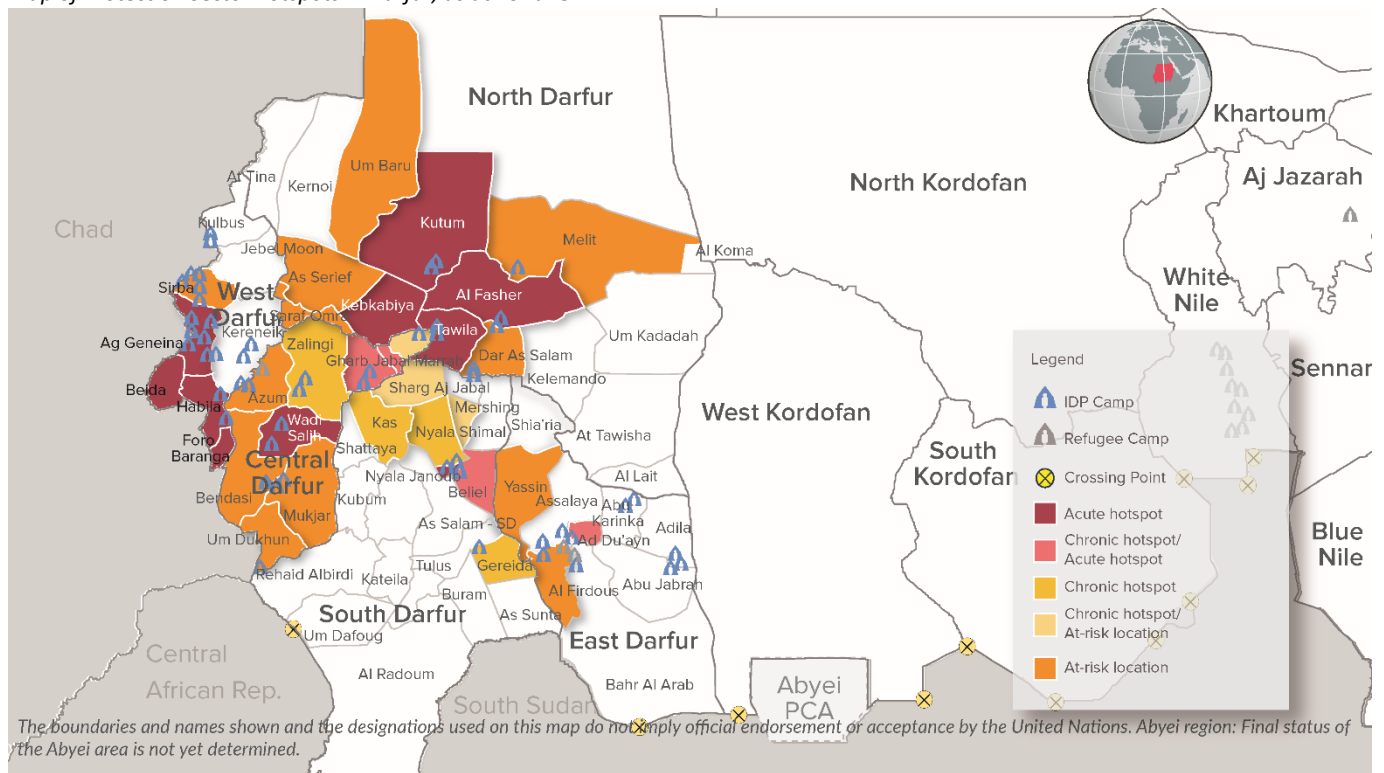
25 June 2023

This note by the Darfur Protection Sector is based on inputs from partners, community networks and other sources. It has not been possible to verify all the information below due to access constraints and telecommunications breakdowns.

Key Points

- The protection and humanitarian situation in the Darfur States continues to deteriorate, with parts of the States completely cut-off from all communications, and (almost) no humanitarian access.
- The conflict in several parts of the “Darfurs” has taken on a more ethnic and/or intercommunal dimension engaging a wider set of actors and resulting in more direct and targeted attacks on civilians, including attacks based on ethnic identity.
- There are grave concerns that the conflict will ignite longstanding tensions between communities across the region with devastating consequences for the civilian population.
- A concerning range of violations are regularly reported, including direct attacks on civilians, conflict-related sexual violence, child recruitment, targeted killings, arbitrary restrictions on freedom of movement, deprivation of access to services and ethnic profiling.
- Humanitarian protection actors are severely hampered in their response, including the ability to monitor the protection situation, by the lack of access to cash, breakdowns in communication and widespread insecurity, ongoing lawlessness and looting in many places.
- There are currently no actors tasked and capable of ensuring provision of security and effective protection to the civilian population. This is an urgent protection crisis requiring a comprehensive response that includes a focus on protecting civilians from further physical violence and abuse.

Map of Protection Sector hotspots in Darfur, as at 15 June



Overview

The protection of civilians' situation in the Darfur region continues to deteriorate overall. There are grave concerns that the conflict will ignite longstanding tensions between communities across the region, which will have devastating consequences for the civilian population. While some parts of Darfur have remained relatively calm (notably East Darfur), clashes continued to be reported in North, Central, South and West Darfur while attacks on civilians and criminality were reported across all five Darfur states. Since 15 April, the Protection Sector has identified 21 localities in Darfur as acute hotspots, all of them having seen armed clashes.

Of concern is the deepening of the ethnic dimension to the conflict in the region. This is particularly the case in El Geneina, West Darfur where the clashes now engage a multiplicity of actors and have reportedly included racially motivated attacks on civilians, including community leaders, activists and those trying to flee the conflict. Other parts of Darfur have also witnessed direct attacks on civilians and the increasing mobilisation and/or taking up of arms amongst members of different communities. There are presently no actors tasked and capable of providing effective protection to the civilian population in Darfur. There are reports that Signatory and non-Signatory Armed Groups in various parts of Darfur may increasingly be drawn into the conflict, with indications of increasing cooperation between specific armed groups and parties to the conflict. This drawing in of more actors risks exacerbating the conflict and in particular the ignition of larger-scale violence along intercommunal lines.

The humanitarian situation continues to deteriorate, particularly in El Geneina, Zalingei and Nyala, and other urban areas effectively under 'siege'. Elsewhere, security, supply and cashflow challenges, and the impact the conflict has had on humanitarian assets and operations, inhibit resumption of humanitarian activities at scale.

- **North Darfur:** The past few weeks have seen some major incidents affecting civilian protection. In early June, reportedly, armed Arab militias from Kabkabiya and areas around Kutum joined the fighting in support of conflicting parties. During the clashes, the Kassab IDP camp was reportedly directly targeted by RSF forces and armed Arab militias. In the ensuing violence, it was estimated that 129 people were killed of whom 54 were IDPs from Kassab camp. Kutum market was looted, as well as private residences in the town. UN and NGO facilities were also reportedly looted and vandalized. Civilians in Kutum, now under RSF control, are almost entirely deprived of access to life saving services, including medical care, food and water. On 16 and 19 June, Tawila town came under attack, by RSF and Arab militias, who now control the town. There are reportedly several dozen dead and more injuries. Many thousands have fled the violence in Kutum and Tawila (40,000 and 50,000 approximately according to IOM). While many parts of North Darfur are now under RSF control, El Fasher remains divided. SAF, in collaboration with JPA signatories, appear to have control over the majority of the town.
- **East Darfur:** The overall security situation in East Darfur is stable yet unpredictable. There were no reported hostilities between the SAF and the RSF in June thus far. However, the concentration of RSF troops continues to rise. There has also been an increase in the criminality rate in the entire state, including reported attacks on farmers while working on their farms, looting their seedlings. At the same time there have been instances of intercommunal tension and violence outside Ed Daein: see the description below of the violence that took place between the Tam and Rizegat tribes in Hajilija village over an alleged land dispute, Ad Du'ayn locality.
- **South Darfur:** The general security situation in South Darfur remains tense and unpredictable. Control of Nyala town remains divided, and heavy clashes took place in the town between SAF and RSF over consecutive days from 20 to 24 June, with the heaviest clashes taking place on 24 June in the surroundings of the military base in Nyala town. Residents in the neighbouring areas confirmed the death of at least 9 civilians by mortars or by stray bullets. Reportedly, 8 IDPs in Otash IDP camp were killed as a result of heavy shelling around the camp's environs on 23 June. Clashes between SAF and RSF also took place in Um Dafoug in mid-June, bordering Central African Republic with RSF taking control of the former SAF checkpoint at the border. The situation is also reported to be particularly tense in Kass locality, where control of a vital bridge is at stake.
- **Central Darfur:** June has seen renewed conflict in Central Darfur. Following the attempt by RSF to take the SAF base on 17 May (after which all telecommunications in Zalingei went dark), renewed fighting broke out on 14 June leading to several civilian casualties. On 22 June a renewed offensive by RSF to take the SAF base led to 5 children killed and 9 wounded when shells fell on a girls' secondary school in Zalingei. While SAF still control the base in Zalingei, all other major localities except the Jabal Marrah areas have fallen to RSF. In the Jabal Marrah areas the army has, according to reports, assigned SLA-AW security responsibilities and attempted to withdraw towards El Fasher. There have been reports of RSF looting one medical warehouse and burning another one to the ground. Additionally, it has been reported that SAF placed landmines in many roads and alleys within sector 8 of Hasahisa IDP camp and other parts of Zalingei town.
- **West Darfur:** Conflict intensified in El Geneina over the first half of June in El Geneina, culminating in a spate of targeted killings that resulted in the death of the State Governor as well as at least two members of the commission established to investigate crimes pursuant to the 2022 attacks on Krinding IDP camp. In the immediate aftermath of the killing of the State Governor, there was an outflux of an estimated 15,000 people from El Geneina to Chad. RSF and its allied elements are now reported to be in almost complete control of the town. Outside the town, there was an attack on Tendulti by the RSF in early June although no casualties were reported. The situation in the northern corridor (Sirba, Jebel Moon, Kulbus) outside El Geneina is thought to be generally calm, with reports that people are travelling safely to access

functioning markets in Kulbus. Localities in the southern corridor (Beida, Habila and Forobaranga) remain under RSF control.

Main protection concerns

Since the start of the conflict in Darfur, civilians have been severely impacted, with several hundreds of deaths and injuries reported amongst the civilian population in Darfur. The **indiscriminate use of heavy weaponry, shooting and fighting in densely populated civilian areas** has caused much suffering. As the conflict takes on a more ethnic or intercommunal dimension, the region has witnessed more direct attacks against civilians, some of whom are being targeted on account of their profile, including ethnicity, and recent weeks have seen an uptick in **attacks targeting civilians**. Already in El Geneina all 86 IDP Gathering Sites were reportedly burnt, and private homes of groups being specifically targeted have been looted and razed. As a result of the violence, those killed and injured are increasingly estimated to number in the thousands. Water points relied upon by the civilian population, including those from different ethnic backgrounds, have been destroyed or rendered non-functional by those engaged in the fighting. As in many of the State capitals, **civilian objects such as health care facilities serving different communities have been occupied, damaged and/or destroyed**. Recent weeks have seen renewed and intense fighting in El Geneina and there were significant outflows of Sudanese nationals from El Geneina into Chad over 15-17 of June following the killing of the West Darfur Wali on 14 June. Among the outflux were hundreds of people who had been wounded in the recent fighting and were in need of medical treatment in Adre. Elsewhere in West Darfur, Forobaranga and Masterei towns have experienced repeated attacks, with Masterei now largely emptied of its former residents. In North Darfur, Kassab IDP camp was reportedly directly targeted by RSF forces and armed Arab militias during the 3 June clashes in Kutum. The violence caused the displacement of 41,000 individuals (IOM DTM) and dozens of deaths and injuries. Between 16 and 19 June, Tawila town in North Darfur reportedly came under attack by the RSF and armed Arab militias, causing largescale displacement into the surrounding villages, mountains, and towards the Zam Zam IDP camp near El Fasher, as well as into Central Darfur. Dozens of civilians are said to have been wounded and in need of medical evacuation to El Fasher but safe passage is not guaranteed. [Satellite imagery](#) is reported to confirm that various settlements in West, South and North Darfur states have been razed to the ground.

The violence in West Darfur is of particular concern, with an **emerging pattern of targeted attacks against civilians based on their ethnic identities**, allegedly committed by Arab militias and some armed men in RSF uniform. Individuals in positions of leadership or influence of a targeted tribe have also reportedly been singled out for attack. This includes lawyers, human rights defenders, and customary or tribal leaders. Those seeking to flee the violence are reportedly facing checkpoints on the road between El Geneina and the Chadian border, at which men of fighting age are ethnically profiled and granted or denied passage on the basis of tribal membership. **There are also many reports of missing persons, persons having been abducted or disappeared coming from several parts of Darfur** including linked to clashes in places like Kutum, Tawila in North Darfur and El Geneina in West Darfur. As an example, 20 IDP men and youth from El-Salam IDP camp were reportedly arbitrarily arrested and detained on 16 June by RSF while on their way from Nyala town to El-Salam IDP camp and vice-versa. According to the sources, it was reported that the IDPs were tied in their hands and legs, beaten up, intimidated, harassed, and forced to admit that they were spying for SAF, however, IDP s reportedly told RSF that they were only going to Nyala market to purchase some commodities and attend to medical services. Though some of them are reported to have been released, some sources indicated that a number of IDPs are still in custody under unclear circumstances with their fates unknown. In El Fasher, there are reports of increasing arbitrary detentions by parties to the conflict with men of specific ethnicities being most at risk, depending on which part of town they reside in and under which parties' control it is. Parties to a non-international armed conflict that deliberately direct attacks against the civilian population, individual civilians not taking part in hostilities and hospitals, and those who take hostages, are committing war crimes as defined in the Rome Statute. When animated by an intent to persecute a specific group based on ethnic or tribal affiliation, again as per the Rome Statute, those actions also constitute crimes against humanity.

In several areas, **civilian populations are effectively under 'siege' and, unable to move freely or safely to leave their location** and are effectively deprived of access to life-saving services and assistance. In El Geneina, it is reported that civilians of a targeted tribe have been repeatedly displaced between neighborhoods in the town and are now effectively trapped in a small area with no safe way to leave and where they lack access to the necessities of life, including potable water, sufficient food and sanitation infrastructure, access to medical care and decent shelter. The city of Zalingei in Central Darfur is also in a similar situation, with checkpoints surrounding the town and civilians unable to leave safely, or for the town to be resupplied. The humanitarian situation is said to be dire although last week one commercial truck is said to have arrived to the town. A communication blackout since mid-May means little information on the situation is available. Other locations understood to be in similar circumstances include Garsila, Habila and Masterei. In a number of locations, **controlling forces are alleged to have imposed illegal taxes or 'protection fees' to civilians as well as traders**, while civilians are reportedly routinely robbed of belongings at the many checkpoints that have been established.

Since the start of the conflict in Darfur, **women and girls have been subject to a heightened risk of GBV**. On 15 June, the Federal Ministry of Social Welfare recently reported that they had documented 25 GBV cases in Darfur since April 15. **Various reports of conflict-related sexual violence (CRSV) continue to be received by the Sector**. In one example, in early June, a group of armed men, allegedly RSF affiliates, intercepted three minibuses with passengers from El Fasher to Nyala at an area half-way from Menawashi to Doma. The passengers were looted of their personal belongings including money, mobile phones and clothing. The armed men intentionally separated the male and female passengers; forcing all women and girls in one minibus and detoured it

into a busy area. After an hour and a half the minibus returned and the women and children released. The armed men had allegedly raped all women and girls under gun points. It is not known if the survivors have been able to access services. Multiple reports of GBV from both Kutum and Tawila have been received following clashes there, whilst there are also reports of GBV from urban areas such as El Fasher allegedly committed by parties to the conflict. There are also multiple reports of rape and other forms of GBV coming out of El Geneina. **Response services have collapsed in many places with only 25% of GBV responders operational across the country.** For these responders, access remains a major concern. Even where GBV services are available, GBV survivors often face challenges due to the heightened security situation and movement restrictions, and there is a limited supply of PEP kits in health centres.

A large number of cases of **grave violations against children in the Darfur region including killing, injury, sexual violence have been reported since the current conflict began. Cases of child recruitment into armed elements have been confirmed and verified in Darfur**, which is an extremely concerning trend given that the current situation, including the closure of schools, means that many children have no access to social services of any kind, and are therefore at heightened risk of recruitment as well as other negative coping mechanisms and trafficking.

In many locations, civilians' **freedom of movement is severely curtailed, due to the general security situation and risk of physical harm but also owing to the establishment of checkpoints around major towns by parties to the conflict or other armed groups, and banditry along major roads.** A number of towns are divided between SAF or RSF and their affiliates with men, foreigners (including refugees) and specific ethnic groups facing increased risks navigating the many checkpoints and the arbitrary screenings that take place. This has a devastating impact on civilians' ability to move to seek medical attention, access basic goods or to flee safely to other locations. With the rainy season now having started farmers will need to access agricultural land in order to plant (notwithstanding the fact that many will lack access to support with agricultural inputs). This is a traditional flashpoint between farming and herding communities, with disputes often triggering larger-scale violence. The conflict has led to a disruption in support to crop protection mechanisms and a vacuum in civilian protection. This means we **expect to see an increase in incidents related to the agricultural season and already the Sector has received multiple reports of violations**, including GBV when women farmers have sought to access farms. As an example, in Garsila, Central Darfur, Arab tribesmen allegedly supported by RSF, are reportedly preventing civilians to access and clean their farmland, threatening to kill them in case they insist to do so. Farmers were told by Arab nomads that civilians should stop thinking about their farms this year as they (Arabs) are the real owners of the land. As another example in mid-June in East Darfur, a dispute over farming land between 2 tribes (Tam and Rizegat) in Hajilija village, Ad Du'ayn locality led to a clash that resulted in the death of one man. Later, the other tribe is alleged to have burnt 40 shelters and looted shops belonging to the opposing tribe. This also led to the displacement of 120 households to Ad Du'ayn town. Several reports from El Fasher have also been received of assaults and threats against women seeking to access farmland.

Many parts of Darfur are affected by **lawlessness and looting.** This has affected all of the State capitals, and continues, particularly in El Geneina, Nyala and Zalingei. Many other towns are also believed to have been affected, including Kutum and Tawila in North Darfur. There is also **widespread criminality on major roads linking the various towns and villages of Darfur, further complicating any ability to resume humanitarian operations and inhibiting the safe evacuation of the wounded and for civilians to flee hotspot or at-risk locations.** The Protection Sector has received reports of at least 75 instances of armed robbery, theft or looting across the Darfurs since 15 April. A typical example, on 18 June a group of unidentified armed perpetrators on board a 4x4, shot at and intercepted several commercial vehicles near Ma'ali area along Nyala–El Daein road and robbed the passengers of their belongings.

Large numbers of Darfuris have been forcibly displaced, many for the second, third, etc time in their lives, since the start of the conflict. At least **120,000 individuals have fled the violence in West Darfur into neighbouring Chad**, with many more having arrived in recent days and many still awaiting registration. Others have fled to South Sudan or the Central African Republic. In Darfur itself, there are **614,805 newly-displaced IDPs in Darfur as a result of the conflict according to IOM DTM (18 June), while Darfuris comprise over 31% of the total newly displaced IDP population in Sudan since the start of the conflict.** All 5 Darfur States have seen new IDPs. In the past couple of weeks, new displacement took place in Nyala and Zalingei towns owing to renewed clashes, whilst El Fasher witnessed the arrival of thousands of new IDPs from Kutum and Tawila, adding to the growing IDP caseloads. New IDPs continue to arrive daily into Ed Daein from other parts of Sudan including Khartoum. Most move on in days but others stay longer. **IDPs arriving in or displacing within towns are sheltering with host families, or in schools and other public buildings, sometimes within existing IDP camps or establishing new gathering points (sometimes out in the open) and in need of humanitarian assistance.** Where there is access, such as in El Fasher, partners are able to assess their needs but response remains constrained owing to limited supplies, cashflow challenges, etc. The majority of IDPs newly arriving from Tawila are women and children, including UASCs, and need shelter, food, access to healthcare, psychosocial support and NFIs according to partners.

The **Darfur region is facing an acute humanitarian crisis including shortages of food, water, fuel, electricity, medicines, and cash with over 5.5m Darfuris targeted for humanitarian assistance**, according to the [revised HRP](#). Disruptions to markets, banking and telecommunications infrastructure, the collapse of many basic services including electricity, water and healthcare as well as the soaring prices of fuel, suspension of or limited access to humanitarian programmes, have had a severely negative impact on the civilian population of all parts of Darfur including major towns such as Zalingei, Nyala, Kutum and El Geneina. To give an example, recent assessment by REACH relying on Key Informants who had fled Nyala to CAR, suggests that insecurity and road closures are

preventing people from leaving conflict-affected areas in South Darfur safely, while nearly all KIs reported basic services that were no longer available, including education facilities, markets and shops, healthcare facilities and electricity networks. **Multiple IDP and refugee camps, settlements, and gathering sites with whom partners remain in contact are reporting dire conditions** due to the overall lack of basic goods and services, with increased cases of malnutrition and vaccine-preventable deaths.

Many humanitarian actors are unable to provide urgent support to parts of Darfur owing to the active conflict, insecurity and other access constraints. Some parts of Darfur are completely inaccessible with almost no humanitarian partners present and operational, such as El Geneina, Nyala and Zalingei. Elsewhere, such as in El Fasher, response is hampered by lack of access to supplies and cash. In El Daien/East Darfur, increased criminality has hampered humanitarians to access persons we serve. There have only been limited and one-off commercial or humanitarian resupply movements into some cities. The **ceasefires brokered between the main conflicting parties have only had limited effect in Darfur**, where there are more actors involved, many of which lack effective command and control structures and who are motivated by a variety of factors.

Protection response

In most parts of Darfur partners have suspended operations. However, Protection Sector partners are engaging in response where there is humanitarian access, and partners in El Fasher, for example, are active in the provision of GBV, child protection and psychosocial support services for the new IDP caseload. Sector partners in Nyala have also been able to support needs assessment and monitoring of the protection situation of new IDPs. While operating in Zalingei is extremely difficult, protection partners in Um Dukhum, Golo and Rokero managed to conduct rapid protection assessments in the last week. In Ed Daien, the situation is more stable and partners are providing limited protection services, including the undertaking of rapid protection assessments (two conducted so far). Across Darfur, due to the limited physical humanitarian presence, Sector partners continue to rely mostly on remote protection monitoring through community-based protection networks and contacts on the ground. However, the lack of network coverage is severely challenging efforts to reach out to affected populations.

Conclusions and key messages

- ***This is an urgent and multifaceted protection crisis requiring a comprehensive response that includes a focus on protecting civilians from further physical violence and abuse. The Protection Sector calls on the international community to undertake all reasonable measures to restore peace and security in the region as well as providing for robust and adequately resourced protection of civilians' mechanisms.***
- ***Parties to the conflict are urged to ensure the commitment of all persons acting under their instructions, direction or control to the provisions of the Jeddah Declaration, and to their core obligations under IHL. This includes refraining from attacks expected to cause excessive civilian harm relative to the military objective sought, allowing civilians to leave areas of active conflict safely, facilitating civilians' access to humanitarian assistance and enabling the transport of wounded in need of medical care.***
- ***There is a pressing need for parties to the conflict in Darfur to end rape and other forms of sexual violence immediately, and to uphold the protection of women, children and other vulnerable groups. The Protection Sector strongly urges armed actors, relevant authorities and other stakeholders to take measures to prevent and respond to CSRV.***
- ***Indications that parties engaged in the violence in Darfur may have committed war crimes or crimes against humanity warrant accelerated efforts to secure sustained and enforceable ceasefire undertakings in Darfur, alongside humanitarian access. This is necessary to provide credible safeguards against potential (re-)occurrence of such acts. The establishment and implementation of robust monitoring mechanisms are essential for effectively monitoring the compliance of all parties involved in the conflict to IHL, including facilitating independent humanitarian access, and holding them accountable for any violations.***
- ***Humanitarian access is also necessary to enable provision of life saving humanitarian assistance in accordance with the international humanitarian law obligations and the terms of the Jeddah Declaration and more urgency is required to the efforts to explore humanitarian access to the Darfurs and the establishment of humanitarian corridors. To resume humanitarian operations at the scale required, it is imperative that space for humanitarian operations be secured. This encompasses supply lines, offices and warehousing facilities, as well as secure travel to reach affected populations inside and outside state capitals.***
- ***The restoration of telecommunications networks, electricity grids, banking facilities and regular market operations must also be prioritized to facilitate the humanitarian response and enable the civilian population to access basic services and there is a need for high-level engagement with telecommunications, electricity and banking service providers to restore essential services.***